

Springhares

PHYLUM	Chordata
CLASS	Mammalia
ORDER	Rodentia
SUBORDER	Anomaluromorpha
FAMILIES	2
SPECIES	9

This group comprises the springhare and scaly tailed flying squirrels (anomalurids)—2 unusual families of rodents confined to Africa. They have anatomical features that link them with cavylike rodents, but genetic analysis supports their classification in a different suborder. The springhare is a large jumping kangaroo-like rodent of arid

habitats, with long hind limbs, wide hooflike rear claws, very long brush-tipped tail, and prominent ears—like those of a hare. Anomalurids have a gliding membrane, although they are not related to flying squirrels of Asia and North America or the colugos. The rough scales on the underside of their tail prevent slippage when they land on tree trunks after gliding.

BOUNDING TO SAFETY
Springhares escape their nocturnal predators with kangaroo-like leaps. This East African springhare (Pedetes surdaster) is less common than the South African species.



Pedetes capensis

Southern African springhare



Location C. and E. Africa to southern Africa

Length 13¼–18 in (33.5–45.5 cm)

Tail 12–19¼ in (31–48.5 cm)

Weight 5½–7¾ lb (2.5–3.5 kg)

Social unit Individual

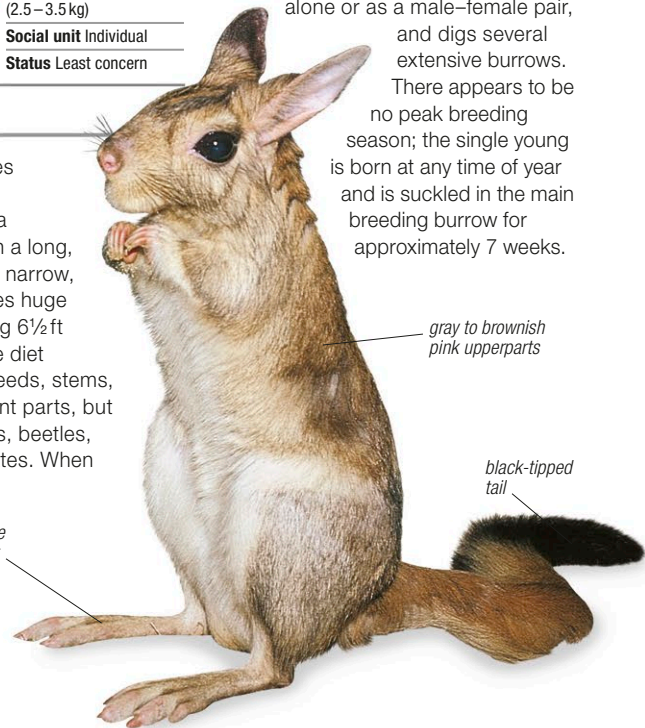
Status Least concern



One of only 2 species of springhares, this species resembles a rabbit kangaroo with a long, bushy tail and large, narrow, upright ears. It makes huge leaps, easily covering 6½ ft (2 m) per bound. The diet consists mainly of seeds, stems, bulbs, and other plant parts, but also includes locusts, beetles, and other invertebrates. When

feeding, it tends to bend forward and lope rabbitlike on all fours. The 5 large front claws are specialized for digging. When bounding at full speed, its tail curves up; when sitting up, its tail is used as a support. The Southern African springhare sleeps resting on its haunches, head tucked between its hind legs, and the tail wrapped around the whole body. Nocturnal, it lives

alone or as a male–female pair, and digs several extensive burrows. There appears to be no peak breeding season; the single young is born at any time of year and is suckled in the main breeding burrow for approximately 7 weeks.



very large hind feet

gray to brownish pink upperparts

black-tipped tail

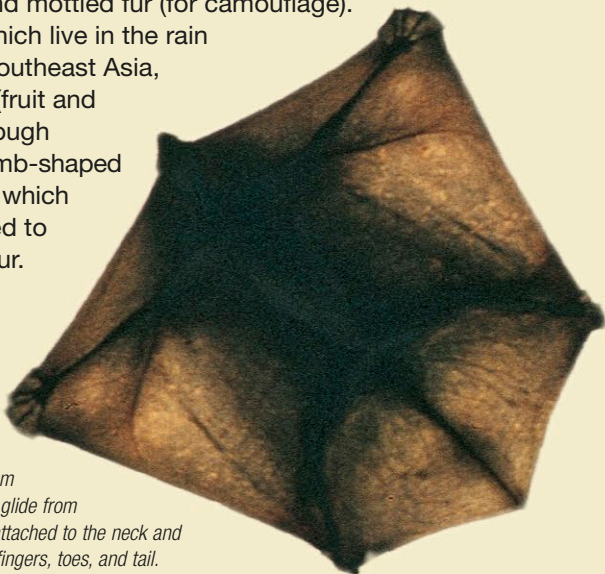
Colugos

PHYLUM	Chordata
CLASS	Mammalia
ORDER	Dermoptera
FAMILIES	1 (Cynocephalidae)
SPECIES	2

By extending a strong membrane that surrounds their body (the patagium), colugos (also known as flying lemurs) are able to glide more than 330 ft (100 m) between trees, with very little loss in height. The term “flying lemur” is misleading, however, as these mammals are not lemurs

and are not capable of true flight. About the size of a domestic cat, they have large eyes, a blunt muzzle, strong claws for climbing, and mottled fur (for camouflage). Colugos, which live in the rain forests of Southeast Asia, strain food (fruit and flowers) through peculiar comb-shaped lower teeth, which are also used to groom the fur.

GLIDER
A kite-shaped membrane called the patagium allows colugos to glide from tree to tree. It is attached to the neck and to the tips of the fingers, toes, and tail.



Cynocephalus variegatus

Malayan colugo



Location S.E. Asia

Length 13–16½ in (33–42 cm)

Tail 7–10½ in (17.5–27 cm)

Weight 2–4½ lb (0.9–2 kg)

Social unit Variable

Status Least concern



Although still common in some areas, numbers of this species have declined rapidly in logged and farmed regions. It has a small head relative to its body with large eyes, little, rounded ears, and a blunt muzzle. The fine, short fur is brownish gray with red or gray on the back, often with lighter flecks to mimic lichen-covered branches, and paler on the underside. The Malayan

colugo is active in twilight and at night, eating soft plant parts such as flowers, fruit, buds, and young leaves, and scraping up nectar and sap with its comblike lower incisor teeth. It lives alone or in small, loose groups, inhabiting tree-holes or resting among dense foliage high in the treetops. After a gestation period of about 2 months, the single offspring clings to its mother as she leaps and glides among the trees and is weaned by 6 months.

